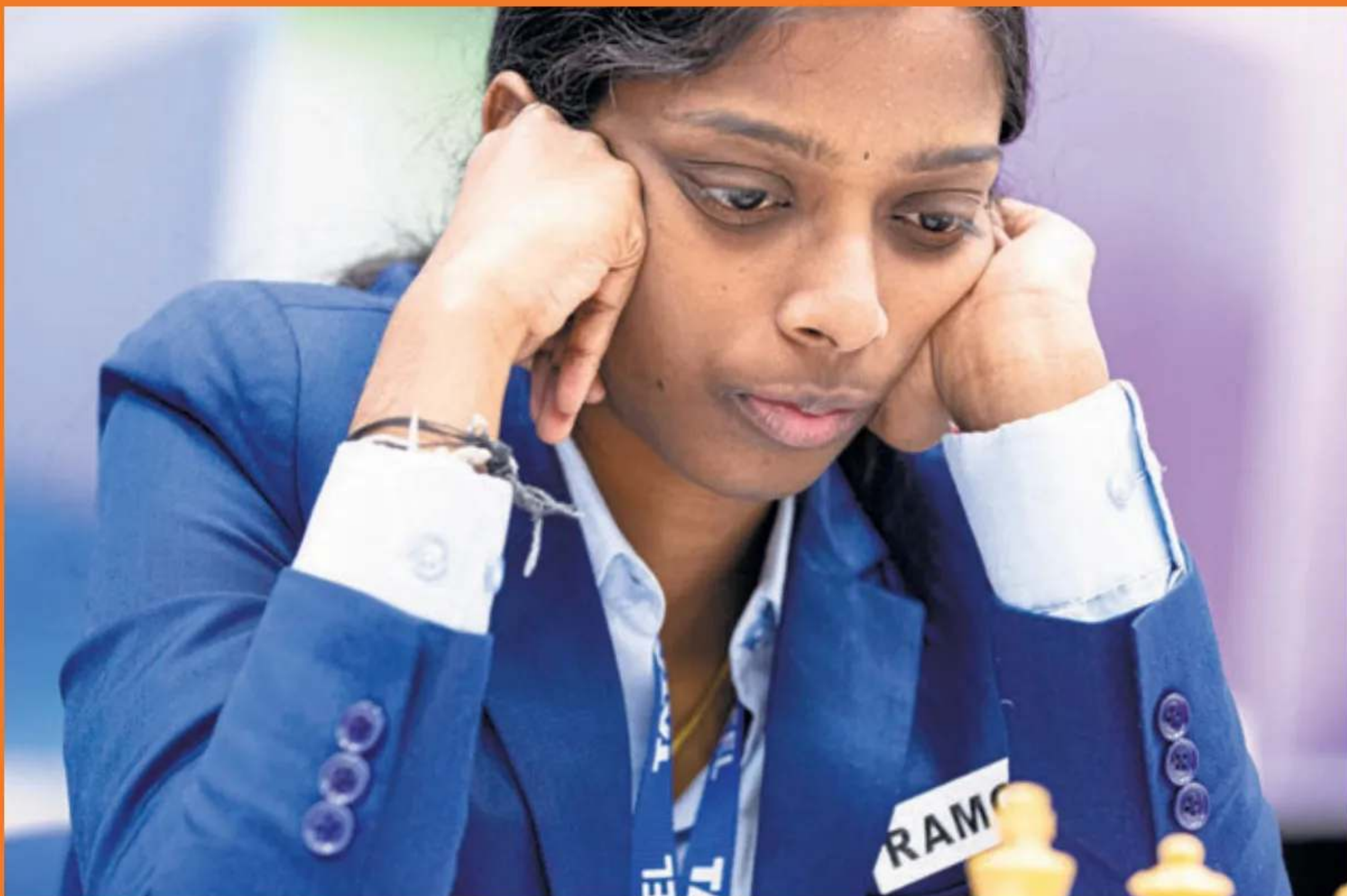




players belong to the World's top-10 list, Vaishali took the path that's least expected from a lesser-rated player. Like Vidit in the Open section of the 2023 FIDE Grand Swiss, Vaishali took the honours in the women's section. She also ensured one of the two spots available for the Candidates with a round to spare!

Though new to the world's elite and thereby lacking the experience of playing top notch tournaments,



Format (Women): Players compete in a double round-robin basis for a total of 14 rounds. The time control is 90 minutes for the first 40 moves, followed by 30 more minutes for the rest of the game. There's a 30-second increment starting on move 1.

No draw agreement before Black's 40th move.

Prizes: Total prize-fund is 250,000 euros – 24,000 euros for the winner, 18,000 euros for the runner-up, and 12,000 euros for the second runner-up. Additionally, players receive 1,750 euros for every half-point scored.

Vaishali could find the going tough. Being the penultimate seed, there are no expectations from her and that could work to her advantage. She surely has the game to scale greater heights in the women's circuit and this opportunity should make her a better player.

In her own opinion, she is getting better at dealing with disappointing results. Unlike her brother Praggnanandhaa, Vaishali finds it difficult to overcome losses or blown-away winning possibilities. A good start should steady the nerves and thereafter, Vaishali can be expected to spring surprises. With coach Ramesh around in Toronto, she will be in her comfort zone.

Vaishali appears better prepared with a few more additions to her opening repertoire. No doubt, she has sound chess basics, good calculating abilities and defensive skills. In addition, the rise of her brother in the chess world has inspired this simple girl to perform amazingly well.

The past six months have been amazing for Vaishali. A place in the

Steady rise: The past six months have been amazing for Vaishali. A place in the Candidates, the Grandmaster title and the Arjuna Awards have all come her way. HARRY GIELEN

Candidates, the Grandmaster title and the Arjuna Awards have helped improve her self-belief and made her work harder.

Unlike in the past, she can be expected to play to win tournaments. In Toronto, even a draw against six higher rated rivals is going to fetch her rating points that could take 15th-ranked Vaishali closer to the World top-10 bracket.

Vaishali has everything to play for. Though no one counts this rising Indian to be among the favourites for the title, expect this determined girl to make a strong bid. Expect her to play freely, bring down or slow down the progress of the front-runners and stay in the hunt.

Candidates tournament from April 4-22. Rest days on April 8, 12, 16 & 19. Tie-break rounds on April 22 if required.